
BRAZIL**Terry Gilliam, 1985**

Terry Gilliam's *Brazil* (which takes its title from a 1939 song) is part satire, part fantasy. It is set in a surreal future where people are trapped in humdrum urban lives controlled by a Kafkaesque Ministry of Information. When an innocent man is wrongly arrested due to a bureaucratic error and dies in custody, records functionary Sam Lowry (Jonathan Pryce) tries to make it right, and in the process falls in love with the enigmatic Jill (Kim Greist) whom he fears may be a terrorist working against the ministry. The movie is probably the most complete representation of Gilliam's absurdist humor.

DOWN BY LAW**Jim Jarmusch, 1986**

Shot on a low budget in black and white, *Down by Law* adopts a laconic take on life. At some moments bleak and others cheerful, it tells the story of three misfits—down-at-heel disc jockey Zack (Tom Waits), hustler pimp Jack (John Lurie), and lost Italian tourist Bob (Roberto Benigni)—who happen to end up sharing a prison cell and decide to make a break for it. As they go on the run through the Louisiana forests, the story seems part dream, part postapocalyptic nightmare.

JESUS OF MONTREAL**Denys Arcand, 1989**

Jesus of Montreal tells the story of a company of actors led by Daniel (Lothaire Bluteau) who are hired by

a priest to perform a passion play. To prepare a thought-provoking production, Daniel draws on academic research relating to the life of Christ, but his novel interpretation of the story upsets the Church authorities, and he finds himself undergoing an ordeal that parallels the Passion itself. The movie seems to challenge the established Church hierarchy, suggesting that it would fail to understand Christ if he returned.

HEARTS OF DARKNESS: A FILMMAKER'S APOCALYPSE**Fax Bahr, George Hickenlooper, and Eleanor Coppola, 1991**

Filmed by the director's wife, Eleanor, this behind-the-scenes documentary follows the troubled making of Francis Ford Coppola's 1979 Vietnam War movie *Apocalypse Now*. The production was beset with difficulties that paralleled the movie's actual narrative, with drunk, high, or uncooperative stars, bad weather, and political problems on location in the Philippines. The movie includes interviews with the surviving protagonists, in which Coppola reflects on the experience: "We were in the jungle, there were too many of us, we had access to too much money, too much equipment, and little by little we went insane."

See also: *The Godfather* 200–05

HARD BOILED**John Woo, 1992**

Hard Boiled is a high-energy thriller about two unconventional Hong Kong cops, Tequila (Chow Yun-Fat) and Alan (Tony Leung), who team up to break a

gunrunning ring. It is relentlessly pacy and uncompromising in its violence, with explosive action scenes and slow-motion gunfights that become almost balletic even as they horrify. The centerpiece of the movie is an action scene in which a handheld camera follows the two cops in a single shot, guns blazing, through a hospital unit and up in an elevator to another floor. Woo's action style has since been widely imitated.

RESERVOIR DOGS**Quentin Tarantino, 1992**

Tarantino's debut feature focuses on the aftermath of a diamond heist gone wrong, as the gang gathers in a warehouse and tries to identify the traitor in its midst. The movie made Tarantino a star, and drew strong performances from its mostly male cast, including Michael Madsen and Tim Roth. Its ultraviolence is made theatrical by smart, rapid-fire dialogue laced with pop-culture references. Combined with sharp suits and a retro sound track, the movie introduced Tarantino as a new and stylish filmmaker.

See also: *Pulp Fiction* 270–75

NAKED**Mike Leigh, 1993**

Naked follows a young man from Manchester, Johnny (David Thewlis), who, with nowhere else to go, turns up at the London apartment of an old girlfriend (Lesley Sharp). Johnny wanders the streets, where he has chance encounters, including one with night security guard Brian (Peter Wight), who shows Johnny the workings of his mundane job.